



Lobster

Canadian exports to China resume in 2026



From January to September 2025, exports of Canadian lobster to China dropped by 40 percent year-on-year as trade continued to be impacted by the latter's import tariff. Although a new deal was signed in January 2026 that eliminated the tariff, Canadian exporters are aware that it will be an uphill struggle to reclaim their previously-held market share in the face of competition from Viet Nam, Australia and other Asia-Pacific countries. Meanwhile the agreement signed between the United States of America and the European Union in August 2025 has not resulted in the predicted surge of trade in the remaining months of the year, partly due to tensions in other areas of trade and politics.

Production

Specific data on landings are not available but the consensus is that harvests in Canada and the United States from January to September 2025 were lower by about 10 to 15 percent compared to the same period in 2024. Colder water temperatures, dwindling resources and specific to the US East Coast fisheries, a new federal requirement increased the minimum lobster weight from 0.98 lbs to 1.18 lbs, which reduced catch volumes by up to 30 percent in affected regions.

In 2025, Indonesia announced a shift in focus from lobster seed exports toward domestic aquaculture development. Following a two-year trial at the Batam Marine Aquaculture Centre, in September, Indonesia's Ministry of Marine Affairs and Fisheries announced successful harvests of about 1.7 tonnes of sand (*Panulirus homarus*),



bamboo (*Panulirus versicolor*) and pearl lobster (*Panulirus ornatus*) valued at about USD 25.60 per kg. A separate joint harvest in Bali in early 2025 had yielded 2.2 tonnes of lobsters through a partnership between Indonesian and Vietnamese firms. Meanwhile, the Indonesian Government announced a special allocation fund of USD 82 million in 2026 to strengthen coastal aquaculture and expand hatcheries for high-value commodities, including lobster.



Markets and international trade

Exports

Global exports amounted to 144 400 tonnes valued at USD 5.4 billion, with the main supplier being Canada (down by 4 percent in volume year-on-year). Viet Nam, the fourth biggest exporter in January–September 2024, shot up by 160 percent in volume to second place during the same period in 2025.

World imports and exports of lobsters January–September, 2023–2025 (1 000 tonnes)			
	2023	2024	2025
Imports			
China	37.13	43.34	48.40
United States of America	37.80	41.57	43.17
Canada	10.79	9.70	8.75
Other countries	43.21	42.43	40.38
Total imports	128.92	137.04	140.69
Exports			
Canada	72.06	65.39	62.56
Viet Nam	3.23	7.80	20.38
United States of America	22.60	20.91	18.82
Other countries	45.28	43.30	42.64
Total exports	143.18	137.39	144.40

Source: Author's own elaboration based on GTT, 2026. Global Trade Tracker. [Cited 1 January 2026]. www.globaltradetracker.com

Lobster exports

World	+5.10% ↑
Canada	-4.00% ↓
Viet Nam	+160.00% ↑

Canada

During January to September 2025, a total of 54 230 tonnes of live lobster were exported from Canada, continuing the declining trend of the previous years (57 660 tonnes in 2024 and 64 120 tonnes in 2023, year-on-year).

The biggest market for Canadian lobster remained the United States with 30 000 tonnes as compared to 28 740 tonnes in 2024 and 25 850 tonnes in 2023, year-on-year. The last quarter of 2025 is expected to report higher volumes, helped by the fact that from mid-October 2025, Canadian lobster became exempt from US tariffs under the terms of the Canada-United States-Mexico Agreement (CUSMA).

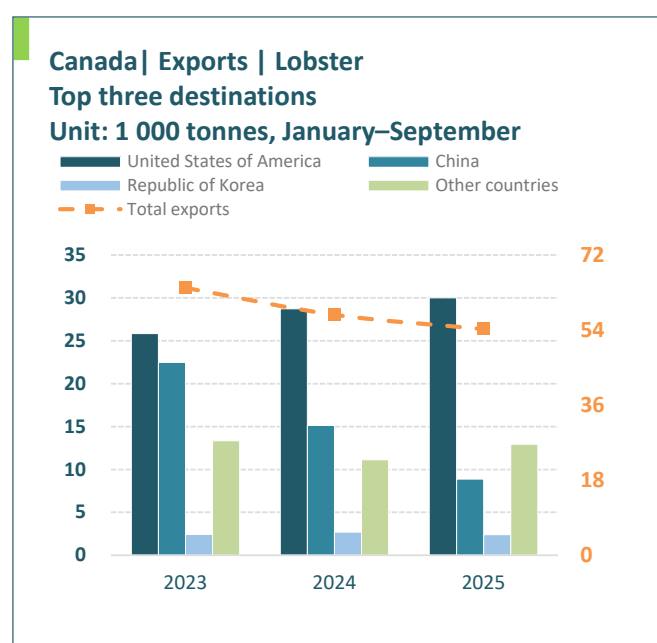
The second-biggest market, China, reported a big drop in the import volume of Canadian lobster (all types) to 8 880 tonnes compared to 15 130 tonnes and 22 490 tonnes in the corresponding periods of 2024 and 2023, respectively, due to the increased 32 percent tariff imposed by China effective 20 March 2025. Canadian exporters therefore heaved a sigh of relief when news broke in early 2026 that the tariff would be eliminated from 1 March onwards following a high-level meeting between Canada and China. However, the path to recovery in the Chinese market is likely to be slippery as in the meantime, competitors such as Viet Nam, Australia and New Zealand had carved out bigger market shares at the expense of Canadian product.

Canadian lobster exports

United States +4.31% ↑

China -41.31% ↓

Republic of Korea -11.00% ↓



Source: Author's own elaboration based on GTT, 2026. Global Trade Tracker. [Cited 1 January 2026]. www.globaltradetracker.com

The export volume of Canadian lobster to the Republic of Korea from January to September 2025 was 2 410 tonnes, a drop of almost 11 percent as compared to 2 690 tonnes year-on-year. For now, the country is the third-largest market for Canadian lobster but this ranking is under challenge. Although Canadian lobster is not tariffed under the 2015 Canada-Korea Free Trade Agreement (CKFTA), there is rising competition from other nations such as Australia and Viet Nam which benefit from geographical proximity and thus, lower high shipping costs (according to one estimate, the cost of shipping products from Canada to the Republic of Korea is at least five times higher than to the United States).

Other countries

South Australian lobster exports to world markets surged during January to September 2025, with one report quoting a total export value of AUD 94.7 million (USD 62.3 million). In the first eight months of 2025 following the December 2024 ending of its four-year ban on Australian lobster, China alone absorbed USD 44.1 million worth of live rock lobster from the country, up by 136 percent year-on-year. In addition, there were increased exports to the United States, Europe, Japan and Singapore. Another significant factor which helped to generate increased export value was the South Australian Government's strategy of expanding the number of wide-bodied freight airplanes able to quickly transport high-value perishable goods. Thirteen international airlines, including China Eastern as a new entrant, now operate out of Adelaide airport.

Exports from Viet Nam in the period under review were valued at USD 712 million (up by 135 percent year-on-year), of which China accounted for USD 556 million (17 365 tonnes). This surge in supplies from Viet Nam can be explained by a strong shift in Chinese demand toward tropical spiny lobster (also known as green lobster) which is farmed in the country in accordance with strict quality controls. In addition, Viet Nam is close to China geographically and benefits from the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) treaty which facilitates trade with China. Other important markets for Viet Nam from January to September were the United States, the European Union and Singapore. With regard to the United States, Viet Nam has expressed concern about the introduction of new strict entry requirements for the US market, effective 1 January 2026. Specifically, under the Marine Mammal Protection Act (MMPA), the United States has officially banned imports, including lobster, from 12 Vietnamese fisheries that have reportedly failed to meet marine mammal protection standards. Meanwhile, exports to the European Union remained constrained by strict requirements for traceability records, proof of legal catch, and food safety certifications.

Imports

During January to September 2025, global imports of lobsters amounted to 140 690 tonnes valued at USD 6.1 billion. The top two markets were China (+11.68 percent in volume over the same period in 2024) and the United States (+4 percent in volume year-on-year).

South Australian lobster exports

China +136.00% ↑

Lobster imports

World +2.66% ↑

Canada +11.68% ↑

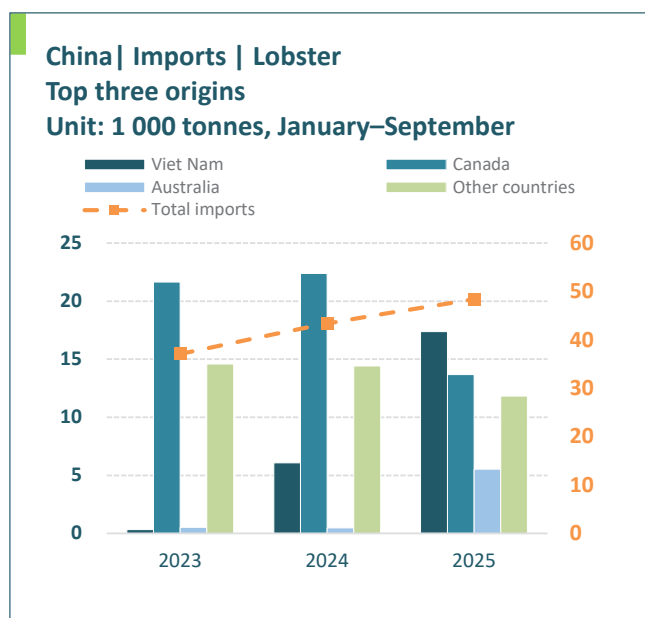
United States +4.00% ↑

China

Canadian live lobster imports into China suffered a setback following the imposition of a 32 percent tariff rate from March 2025. From January to September 2025, these imports amounted to 13 680 tonnes, a significant drop of nearly 40 percent year-on-year.

The void left by lower Canadian lobster imports was filled by increased supplies from Asia-Pacific countries, notably Viet Nam and Australia. From January to September 2025, imports of tropical spiny lobster from Viet Nam were 17 365 tonnes, representing a massive four-digit rise over 606 tonnes and only 33 tonnes in the same periods of 2024 and 2023, respectively. At the same time, trade data suggested that Viet Nam may be acting as a transshipment hub for imports from other countries (including Canada and Australia) which were then re-exported to China.

Australian supplies rose to 5 530 tonnes as compared to only 49 tonnes and 52 tonnes in the comparative periods of 2024 and 2023, respectively, following the December 2024 lifting of the four-year ban on lobster from that country. As mentioned previously, exporters reported that in the first nine months of 2025, China had purchased more than AUD 64 million (about USD 44 million) worth of lobster. At the end of September, prices reportedly hit a five-year high to just over USD 80 per kg ahead of the mid-autumn festival in China.



Source: Author's own elaboration based on GTT, 2026. Global Trade Tracker. [Cited 1 January 2026]. www.globaltradetracker.com

European Union

During January–September, the European Union imported 22 040 tonnes of lobster (live and processed). The main suppliers were Canada (8 270 tonnes; +15.2 percent year-on-year), the United Kingdom (2 660 tonnes; +6 percent) and the United States (1 780 tonnes; -8.7 percent).

With the signing of the EU-US trade deal as mentioned above, US lobster exports to the European Union were expected to pick up in the last quarter of 2025. However, broader trade tensions between the two parties such as possible new US tariffs on certain EU goods, as well as declining catches of lobster in Maine, combined to dampened these expectations.

European Union imports

Canada	+15.2% ↑
United Kingdom	+6.00% ↑
United States	-8.7% ↓

Outlook

Although China has rescinded its nine-month 25 percent tariff policy on Canadian lobster, other competitors had already expanded their market niches in the meantime. Giving up on China is not an option for Canadian exporters as it remains a huge market, but they will continue to look at strengthening their presence in other key Asian markets such as the Republic of Korea, Hong Kong SAR, Taiwan Province of China and Singapore.

Other major exporting nations Viet Nam and Australia will continue to see increased shipments throughout 2026, buoyed by strong regional demand and firm prices; and particularly in the case of Australia, expanded air transport services. However, international shipments from Viet Nam could be impacted in the months ahead due to new regulatory pressures that took effect in the United States from 1 January 2026.

In the Far East, demand for all types and species of lobster will be high during the Chinese New Year festivities in February 2026.